English and killed their general. A thirty-two-year struggle, the First War of Scottish Independence, had formally begun.

MEANWHILE, THE ENGLISH were fighting the French in Aquitaine, and the war was more expensive than Philip IV had anticipated.

He had already declared special taxes on Jews and imposed a highly unpopular tax on the French church. In 1298, he devalued the French currency for the first time: seized it, melted it, and then reissued it with the same value but less silver in it, producing more coins with the same amount of precious metals. This backfired; the coins were immediately viewed as worth less, and inflation set in.[16]

Poorer than when the fight began, Philip IV agreed in 1299 to negotiate a peace with Edward I. To seal the deal, he approved the marriage of his sister Marguerite to the sixty-year-old Edward (Edward's first and much-loved wife, Eleanor of Castile, had died in 1290). Philip IV was half Edward's age, Marguerite only twenty. At the same time, Philip betrothed his five-year-old daughter Isabella to Edward's fifteen-year-old son, the future Edward II of England.

In exchange for peace, he agreed to give no further aid to the Scots. Wallace and his rebels were isolated on their island, and Edward could now turn his full attention their way.